

Manually moving the published *.SWF file into other folder at times gets on your nerves. Here's how to do it automatically.

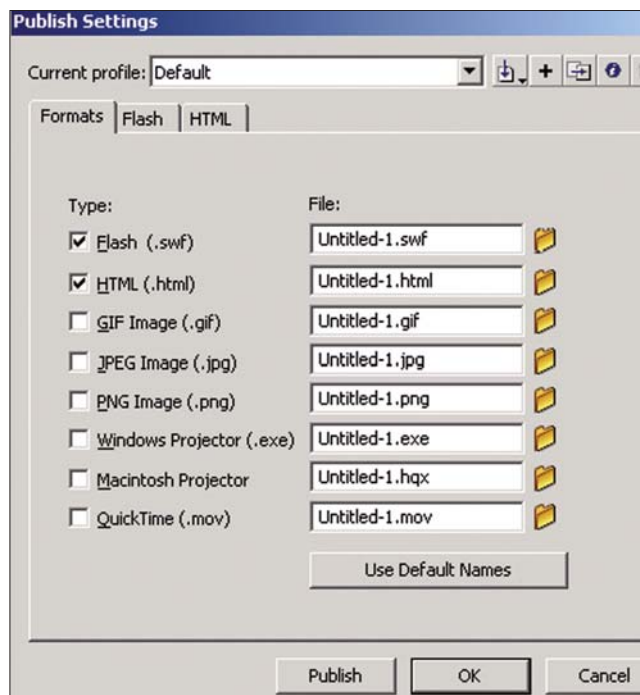
Open the 'Publish Settings' dialog box and click the 'Formats' tab. Click the folder icon present next to the filename for each file type. This will let you choose a specific folder for the selected file type.

If you keep all your *.FLA files in the folder named 'work' and published files (*.SWF) in the 'pub' folder, then type two dots and a colon (..) before the filenames in the Publish Settings. For example, if dummy.fla is saved in folder 'work', and you want the published movie to go into the 'pub' folder, just enter ../dummy.swf for the Flash filename. When you publish the movie or run a test movie, the .swf file will directly be put in to the 'pub' folder.

Replace

Ever stumbled upon a situation where you need to find every instance of something in Flash and replace it with something else?

Choose the Edit menu, and go to 'Find and Replace' to open the 'Find and Replace' dialog box. Here, you can locate and replace text,



The Flash Publish Settings toolbar with the various available options

fonts, symbols, sounds, video clips, bitmaps, and colour.

Here's how to use the magic wand: draw an ellipse and a box on the Stage, and convert them to symbols called ellipse and box. Leave them both on the Stage.

Choose **Edit > Find and Replace**. In the dialog box, choose 'Current Scene' from the 'Search In' menu. Choose 'Symbol' from the 'For' menu. Choose 'Box' from the 'Name' menu. This command will locate all instances of the box symbol. Similarly choose ellipse from the 'Replace With' menu and click 'Replace All'.

Spell Check

Flash has an inbuilt spell checker. Before you start using it, you need to set it up. Choose **Text and then Spelling setup**. There, select all the options you would like. Once done, the checker is set for action.

Type some text into the Stage window. To check it, just select it and run the spell checker. If there are suggestions it likes to offer, a dialog box pretty much like in MS Word opens, and you can select to change the spelling or discard it.

Sharing

Shared Libraries are the bane of Flash MX 2004, and most of you must have already

experienced it in some form or other. If you need to open an original Flash document that an external library came from, so that you can edit one of its symbols, press **File > Open** and locate the file. Flash will tell you that it's already open. This is because the library itself is the document. The only way to close the external library is to undock it from the panel set and press the 'Close Panel' button.

To close all open libraries easily, choose **File > Close All**. Any library or document that is already open will close immediately. Though not the best solution, it's easier.

Reduce Size

Open up a large Flash file in Flash MX 2004, and from the File menu, select 'Save and Compact'. This feature should reduce a 10 MB Flash file to about 2 MB! Perfect for those with dial-up connections!

ActionScripts

Flash MX 2004 comes loaded with a few new ActionScript class files that help you make better movies.

The MovieClipLoader class enables you to write a preloader that has negligible file weight—a necessity for any good preloader, and it lacks loop statements. The best part is, you can then turn it into a component and forget about writing a preloader script again.

One problem, though: the `onLoadProgress()` method of the MovieClipLoader class—the part used to trigger an animation for a progress bar—does not fire when you're testing it on your computer.

Instead of posting a movie with the preloader script to a Web server, and then reposting it every time you make a change, try this: post one jpeg image to the server and use the `loadClip()` method to call the absolute URL. Leave the image on the server permanently so you always have a quick way to test your preloader scripts. ☒

